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Don't interfere with anything in the Constitution. That must be maintained, for it is the only safeguard of our liberties.

Abraham Lincoln
16th US president (1861–1865)

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a republic that primarily championed its people's liberty and rights. Many considered elections only as a means to an end, a way of keeping government in check rather than part of some great democratic ideal.

Madison, the chief architect of the Constitution, argued that it was a republic they were creating, not a democracy. Here, Madison was talking of a democracy such as that of ancient Athens, where all adult citizens had to play an active role in government, which was plainly impractical for a nation such as the US. For him, the key difference was that a republic works by the delegation of government to a small number of people elected by the rest. In 1820, Scottish philosopher James Mill proclaimed such a system of representation to be “the grand discovery of modern times.” His son John Stuart Mill declared it to be the “ideal type of a perfect government.”

What the three men were all describing is now the standard model of democracy, where the people elect representatives to govern and create laws. The gradual shift of Western governments toward this model during the

19th century was, however, perhaps less for its perceived benefits than because other systems had failed.

A work in progress

The delegates at the Constitutional Convention knew the document they had agreed to was a historic achievement but not perfect. At the Convention's close, Benjamin Franklin, aged 81, looked at the half-sun symbol on Washington's chair and declared it was “a rising and not a setting sun,” adding that the Constitution with all its faults was the very best they could obtain.

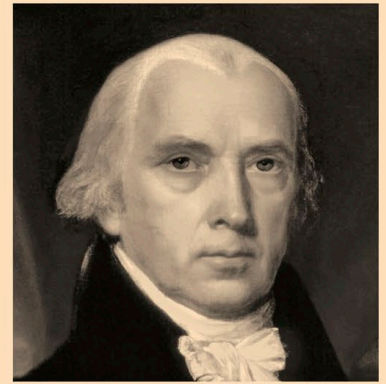
The 1787 Constitution could not produce a government that truly represented the entire nation. It did not set out voting rights; at first, only male property owners could vote at all. The Fifteenth Amendment gave African American men the right to vote only in 1870. In 1920, the Nineteenth Amendment gave women the right to vote; the first states to give American Indians the vote did so in 1924. Yet, by defining a government system empowered by the people, while limiting its powers in order to protect citizens' basic rights, the Constitution set a pattern for modern democratic government that is now the norm across much of the world. ■

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To live under the American Constitution is the greatest political privilege that was ever accorded to the human race.

Calvin Coolidge
30th US president (1923–1929)

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James Madison

Born in 1751, on Belle Grove Plantation in Virginia, Madison was the oldest of 12 children. He graduated from Princeton and was soon involved in the politics of the Revolutionary War, becoming a member of both the Virginia House of Delegates and the Second Continental Congress. He was one of the more prominent Founding Fathers of the United States.

After the war, Madison led the work on the creation of the Constitution. He sponsored the amendments that make up the Bill of Rights and was one of the first leaders of the House of Representatives. Madison was elected fourth president of the United States, serving from 1809 to 1817, at the very peak of the political edifice he had helped create. When he left office in 1817, he retired to his Virginia tobacco plantation, and died there in 1836.

Key works

1787 Speeches at the Constitutional Convention
1787–1788 Articles in *The Federalist*